

WhatsApp Bot Setup — Step by Step

1. Install Python dependencies

```
python -m venv venv
source venv/bin/activate      # Windows: venv\Scripts\activate
pip install -r requirements.txt
```

2. Get your Claude API key

1. Go to <https://console.anthropic.com>
2. Create an account / sign in
3. Go to "API Keys" → "Create Key"
4. Copy it

3. Set up your environment file

```
cp .env.example .env
```

Open `.env` and paste your real API key in.

4. Set up Twilio WhatsApp Sandbox (free, for testing)

1. Go to <https://console.twilio.com>
2. Sign up, verify your phone number
3. In the console, find "Messaging" → "Try it out" → "Send a WhatsApp message"
4. It will give you a sandbox number and a join code (e.g. "join happy-tiger")
5. From YOUR WhatsApp, send that join code to the sandbox number → You're now connected to the sandbox for testing

5. Run the server locally

```
uvicorn main:app --reload --port 8000
```

6. Expose it to the internet (Twilio needs a public URL)

Install ngrok (<https://ngrok.com/download>), then:

```
ngrok http 8000
```

It gives you a URL like: `https://abcd1234.ngrok-free.app`

7. Connect Twilio to your server

1. Back in Twilio console → WhatsApp Sandbox Settings
2. "When a message comes in" → paste: `https://abcd1234.ngrok-free.app/whatsapp`
3. Method: POST
4. Save

8. Test it

Send a WhatsApp message to your Twilio sandbox number, e.g.: "Hi, what time is check-in?"

You should get a Claude-generated reply within a few seconds.

9. Customize

Edit the `SYSTEM_PROMPT` in `main.py` — add your real properties, policies, and escalation rules. This is the single most important file to get right.

Next steps for production

- Replace the in-memory `conversations` dict with a real database (Postgres, Redis, or even a simple SQLite file) so history survives server restarts.
- Move from Twilio Sandbox to a verified WhatsApp Business number (requires Meta Business verification, takes a few days).
- Deploy the FastAPI app somewhere permanent (Railway, Render, or a small VPS) instead of your laptop + ngrok.

- Add logging/alerts so you know when the bot escalates to a human.